

Chapter 19

Transitions

The Challenge

Transitions are a natural part of life in today's organizations. In the late 1980s, Peter Vaill described the challenges that managers face as "permanent white water,"¹ and it's only gotten crazier since then. Transitions can be intoxicating times of accelerated growth into new leadership levels. They can also be some of the most harrowing moments in your career, when you feel you have an equal likelihood of shining or failing gloriously. But transitions are more than just something to survive. Transitions always bring new possibilities. Think about the energy and perspectives that new employees bring to a team. They are the ones most likely to ask, "Why do we do it this way?" Organizations with leaders and employees who are used to making transitions are more likely to adapt to external changes as well. Accordingly, your challenge as a business leader or HR professional is to learn how to thrive in your own transitions and to help the leaders and employees in your organizations navigate the key transitions in their careers.

In this chapter, we will discuss the common types of transitions that leaders make, strategies that leaders and employees can use to successfully navigate these key transition points, and how senior leaders and HR professionals can build organizations that are agile and transition-friendly.

The Bottom Line

Transitions are the Rule, Not the Exception

We tend to think of transitions as a temporary state between times of stability; that is, we take for granted that stability is the norm and a transition is the exception. But what if transitions were the norm and stability was the exception? Tim Hall at Boston University suggests that this is exactly what is happening in the workplace today.² The average person today is likely to change jobs, companies, and even professions several times over the course of their careers. Hall suggests that careers increasingly have become person-driven rather than organization-driven. To succeed in this new reality, leaders and employees need a strong sense of *identity* (self-awareness, a sense of their strengths, and passion) and *adaptability* (the ability to learn, adapt, and build strong relationships). If transitions are the rule, then it is critical that all leaders, and all employees for that matter, to be aware of two things: (1) the typical kinds of transitions they will face in their development; and (2) strategies they can use to navigate through them successfully.

Typical Leadership Transitions

In their book, *Leadership Passages*, David Dotlich, James Noel, and Norman Walker identify nine common transitions that leaders face: joining a company, moving into a leadership role, accepting a stretch assignment, assuming responsibility for a business, dealing with a significant failure for which you are responsible, coping with a bad boss and competitive peers, losing your job or being passed over for a promotion, being part of an acquisition or merger, and living in a different culture.³ All of these require different leadership skills. Promotions into higher management levels represent another set of key transitions that leaders face. Different management levels demand very different things of leaders. Ram Charan, Stephen Drotter, and James Noel identify six key leadership transitions in their book, *The Leadership Pipeline*: from managing yourself (as an individual contributor), to managing others, to managing managers, to functional management, to business management, to group management, to

enterprise management.⁴ Each stage presents new leadership challenges that require the leader to develop new competencies and new approaches, often requiring leaders to give up the very things that made them successful at the previous level. For example, new first-level managers need to stop seeing themselves as technical experts and start thinking about how they are going to manage and motivate the people who report to them.⁵ Similar new demands occur at every level. The functional leader who is promoted to lead a business unit will have to move beyond seeing the world through his or her technical field (e.g., engineering), and learn how to draw on multiple disciplines (e.g., finance, human resources, operations, marketing) to drive the business as a whole.

These models and others remind us that leadership isn't a gradual increase in one's skills. It is more likely to be a series of wrenching nonlinear steps that require leaders to think, feel, and behave differently. Old strategies and old skills won't necessarily work in the new role and can sometimes even get in the way. Organizations are at their best when they help leaders anticipate the changes and navigate through them successfully.

Navigating Transitions Successfully

The types of transitions may vary widely, but the strategies to help you navigate through them remain largely the same. Here are some things to keep in mind as you approach your next transition.⁶

Identify what is required in the new role. Talk to people and read whatever you can about your new role before you move into the job. If you are changing companies, read analyst briefings, annual reports, and news stories in the popular press so you know the challenges facing the new organization. Identify the top priorities and key challenges in your new role. Find out what your new boss thinks about your team. Talk to your team – discover what they are proud of having accomplished in the previous year and what they think would move the team to the next level of excellence in the coming years. If this is a promotion, think about the kind of leadership that is required in the new role. Figure out what new skills are required and what you are going to have to give up.

Contract with your new boss how “success” will be measured. Meet with your new boss to identify what constitutes “success” in your new job and how it will be measured. Too many leaders pursue what they think is most important, only to find out later that their priorities weren’t shared by their boss. Sometimes bosses aren’t clear themselves. Sometimes they don’t know exactly what they want. Sometimes the organization hasn’t agreed on a direction, with different parts demanding different things. All of these are real possibilities but, at the end of the day, you will be held responsible for what you did or didn’t accomplish, so clarify and manage these expectations from the beginning as much as possible.

Get to know your key stakeholders. Identify and meet with the people who will be critical to your success. Ask your new boss, peers, and team to help identify the key stakeholders. In the pressure to get some early wins – which are also important – building relationships with your key stakeholders may be one of the first tasks to fall off your priority list. However, talking to the right people from the start will help ensure that you are doing the *right* things. Ask them to discuss their perspective on: the key challenges facing the company, what your top priorities should be, the traps you should avoid, and their general advice for someone just starting in your role. Remember that if you start to derail in your new role, it will probably be something that other people see long before you do, so take the opportunity to ask them directly to give you feedback if they see you heading in the wrong direction. Keep the door open for future conversations.

Build a development plan. Execution will be your main focus in the first few months, but don’t miss great learning opportunities along the way. Set aside time with your boss in the first couple of months to establish your development goals.

Look for small wins. Michael Watkins in his book *The First 90 Days* suggests that new leaders have three months to prove their value to the company in the new role.⁷ That is the point at which their contributions should begin to outweigh their cost to the company. During the initial 90 days, it’s important to log some early wins to establish your credibility and build momentum for later efforts. As a leader, most of your projects will stretch out for a year or more. Find

ways to break them down so you have some deliverables and measurable results in the first three months.

Taking Action

Prepare for Your Own Transitions

Read one of the books listed at the end of this chapter so you can anticipate the challenges you will face and the strategies that are likely to lead to success. Before you get too busy doing the job, figure out what is really important. Use the Transition Checklist box to assess how you are doing.

Coach Your New Team Members Through Their Transitions

As a manager, you are one of the greatest factors in the success (or failure) of new people who join your team. Establish a high performance environment from the beginning with clear goals and a clear understanding of how “success” will be measured in their new role. As silly as it sounds, make sure the new person has the basics – a badge for the building, a key to their office, and a computer with email that works. Introduce them to the larger team. Walk them through a transition checklist (like the one provided in this chapter). Connect them with key stakeholders and other important people in their network. Help them identify some early small wins. Discuss their development goals for the year. Provide early, direct feedback if they start to wander off course or clash with the culture. Build a relationship that encourages questions.

Build a Transition-Friendly Organization

Use rigorous selection systems that are reliable and valid (e.g., structured interviews that have been validated) to select people who have the skills that they will need to succeed.⁸ Build a culture where managers feel responsible and are held accountable for the success of new employees in their group. Introduce new employee orientation materials and programs if you don’t have them already. Require that performance goals be established in the first 30 days of a new assignment

Your Transition Checklist

My Manager

I have met with my manager, and we have discussed:

- ☐ my manager's assessment of the team I am taking over;
- ☐ how "success" will be measured in this job (including the specific goals and deliverables that will be expected of me in the coming year);
- ☐ challenges and barriers that I am likely to face and my manager's ideas on how I might address them;
- ☐ key stakeholders who I should meet with;
- ☐ resources that I will need to be successful in this role;
- ☐ my development goals and long-term career aspirations.

My Direct Reports

- ☐ I have met with all of my direct reports to discuss the health of the team and the opportunities that they see to move it to the next level.
- ☐ I have met with each of them to discuss their performance goals, deliverables, and future career aspirations.

My Network

- ☐ I have identified the key people I will work with in this new role (senior leaders, thought leaders, peers, key people in other departments, customers, suppliers) and have scheduled meetings to meet with them within the first two months.
- ☐ I have identified the people I need to meet with regularly in this job and set up ongoing meetings with each of them.
- ☐ I have explicitly asked my boss, peers, and direct reports to give me feedback if they see me start to veer off course.

My Performance

- ☐ I have identified my top three priorities in this job.
- ☐ I have identified at least three small wins I will achieve in the first 30–90 days.
- ☐ I have documented my performance and development goals for the year.
- ☐ I have started to map out long-term performance goals for myself and the team.

and development goals in the first 60 days. Create a culture where it's common for people to move into new jobs or take on significant new responsibilities every two or three years. Encourage cross-training and job rotations. Make open jobs visible to everybody. Consider internal candidates first and establish a “promote from within” culture. Consider structuring your leadership development training around the key leadership transitions (e.g., first-time managers, new functional managers/executives, new business managers/executives) since these are the times when leaders can benefit from guidance the most. Provide special onboarding support for senior leaders joining the company (e.g., assigning a peer mentor, providing an internal coach, assigning them an experienced executive assistant who know the company well). Build a transition guide that all employees can access. Then monitor how you are doing by tracking six-month and one-year turnover rates (and other metrics – see chapter 4) for key jobs in the company.

To Learn More

- Bradt, G., Check, J., & Pedraza, J. (2006). *The new leader's 100 day action plan: How to take charge, build your team, and get immediate results*. Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley & Sons.
- Charan, R., Drotter, S., & Noel, J. L. (2001). *The leadership pipeline: How to build the leadership-powered company*. John Wiley & Sons.
- Dotlich, J. L., Noel, J. L., & Walker, N. (2004). *Leadership passages: The personal and profession transitions that make or break a leader*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass.
- Watkins, M. (2003). *The first 90 days: Critical success strategies for new leaders at all levels*. Boston: Harvard Business School Press.

